

C01 — Football Event Intelligence

Coaching Memo

To: Coaching / Performance Staff

Subject: Chelsea FCW high regains and post-regain attacking threat

Season: 2023/24 FA Women's Super League

Decision

Do not change Chelsea's high-pressing approach materially on the basis of this analysis alone.

Chelsea are one of the stronger teams in the league at regaining possession high up the pitch, but the evidence does not show that they do so at a meaningfully higher rate than their closest competitive peers, Manchester City and Arsenal.

Chelsea show a possible advantage in creating dangerous attacks after high regains, but that advantage is too uncertain and too sensitive to reasonable changes in the analytical definition to treat as a proven strength.

The most useful next coaching question is therefore not "Should Chelsea press more?" but "Can Chelsea improve what happens immediately after they win the ball high?"

What the analysis shows

The analysis separates the process into four stages:

Opportunity → High regain → Post-regain attack → Dangerous attack

This matters because raw high-regain totals can be misleading. Teams face different numbers of situations in which a high regain is possible.

1. Chelsea do not win the ball high more often than their main peers

After adjusting for the number of relevant opponent possessions:

Team	High-regain opportunities	High regains	Rate
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Manchester City	1,155	98	8.5%
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Arsenal	1,185	99	8.4%
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Chelsea	1,245	94	7.6%
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Chelsea actually faced more opportunities to regain the ball high than either Manchester City or Arsenal.

Once that exposure is taken into account, Chelsea's high-regain frequency is broadly similar to the other two teams rather than clearly superior.

Uncertainty checks also show that the observed differences are too small to conclude that Chelsea are meaningfully better or worse than either peer.

2. Chelsea turn high regains into attacks at a similar rate

A post-regain attack is defined as producing either a shot or a successful penalty-area entry within 15 seconds of winning possession high.

Team	Post-regain attack rate
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Chelsea	38.3%
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Arsenal	37.1%
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Manchester City	36.9%
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Chelsea are slightly higher descriptively, but the difference is small.

The evidence does not support treating Chelsea's attack conversion as clearly better than Manchester City or Arsenal.

3. The strongest Chelsea signal is chance quality after the regain

A dangerous attack is defined as producing at least 0.10 total StatsBomb xG within 15 seconds of the high regain.

Team	Dangerous attacks per high regain
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Chelsea	11.7%
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Arsenal	9.5%
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Manchester City	8.7%
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Chelsea have the highest observed rate.

This is the most interesting signal in the analysis, but it should be treated cautiously. Chelsea produced only 11 dangerous attacks under the primary definition, and the differences against Manchester City and Arsenal remain statistically uncertain.

The pattern also changes when stricter danger thresholds or different post-regain time windows are used. Chelsea therefore look stronger under the primary definition, but the evidence is not consistent enough to call this a distinctive competitive advantage.

Coaching interpretation

The analysis does not support increasing pressing intensity simply to create more high regains.

Chelsea already perform at approximately the same level as their strongest domestic peers in generating high regains. There is no evidence here that pressing more aggressively would produce a meaningful competitive advantage. There is, however, a potentially useful signal after possession is regained. Chelsea's best relative numbers appear in the quality of attacks created following high regains rather than in the frequency of the regains themselves.

Recommendation

Maintain the current high-regain approach.

If additional coaching or video work is undertaken, focus it on the first actions after the regain:

- the first pass or carry;
- forward options available immediately after possession changes;
- player positioning around the regain;
- speed of exploiting temporary defensive disorganisation;
- decision-making between immediate penetration and retaining possession.

The objective should be to understand whether Chelsea can make the promising post-regain attacking signal more repeatable, rather than simply trying to win the ball high more often.

What this analysis does not establish

This is observational event-data analysis. It does not show that Chelsea's pressing system causes the attacking outcomes observed.

The event data also does not fully capture:

- the coaching intention behind each press;
- player pressing roles;
- opponent build-up strategy;
- match and score-state context;
- physical load;
- whether the correct tactical decision was made in individual sequences.

Before recommending a tactical change, the strongest next evidence would therefore come from combining these event-data findings with targeted video review of Chelsea's high-regain sequences.

Bottom line

Chelsea's high-regain performance is strong, but not demonstrably distinctive from Manchester City and Arsenal.

There is not enough evidence to justify a major pressing change.

The most promising area for further coaching analysis is how Chelsea exploit the ball immediately after winning it high, not simply how often they regain it.